

User Research Findings: Small-Business Brain

Overview

This document compiles primary research gathered for the Small-Business Brain project, a WhatsApp-first AI agent for Pakistani SMEs. Research includes a 7-response survey of small business owners and a detailed user interview conducted directly over WhatsApp with a home food business owner (referred to here as the Interviewee).

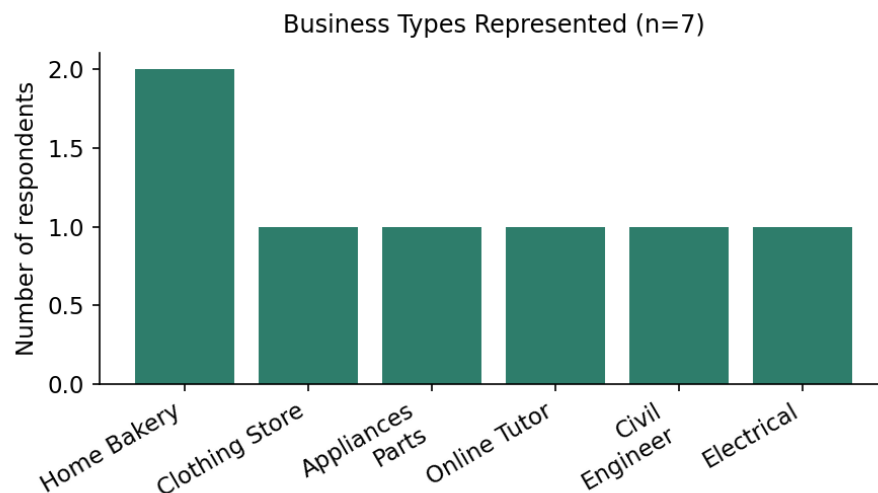
Methodology

- Survey distributed to small business owners across multiple sectors (7 responses collected)
- Semi-structured follow-up interview conducted over WhatsApp with one respondent, a home-based food business owner, to go deeper on daily workflow and pain points

Part 1: Survey Findings

Respondent profile

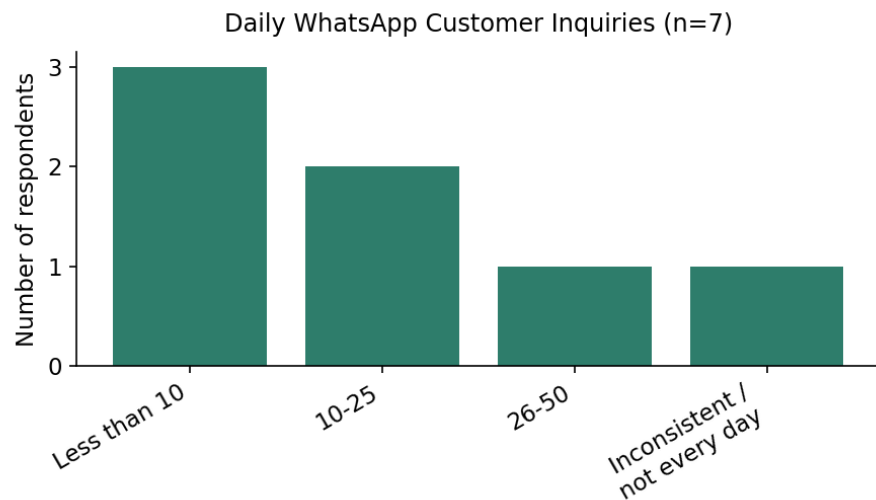
- Business types represented: Home Bakery (2), Clothing Store (1), Appliances Parts (1), Online Tutor (1), Civil Engineer (1), Electrical (1)
- Business age: 1-3 years (3), less than 6 months (2), 6 months-1 year (1), 5 years (1)



Note: one respondent works in construction/civil engineering and flagged that the survey questions were framed around retail-style businesses and did not map cleanly onto their field. Worth accounting for in future survey design.

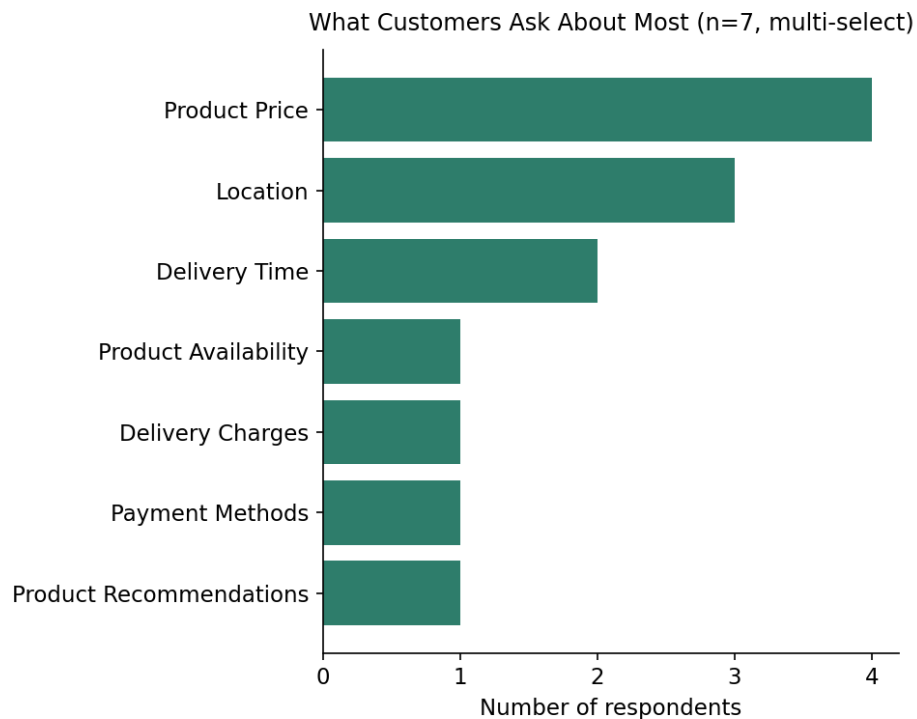
Communication volume and channels

- Daily WhatsApp inquiries: less than 10 (3), 10-25 (2), 26-50 (1), inconsistent/not everyone (1)
- 6 of 7 respondents already use WhatsApp Business
- Primary channel for managing inquiries: WhatsApp (6), phone calls (1), Instagram (2), with some overlap across channels
- Time spent replying to customer messages daily: less than 30 minutes (4), 30-60 minutes (1), 1-2 hours (2)



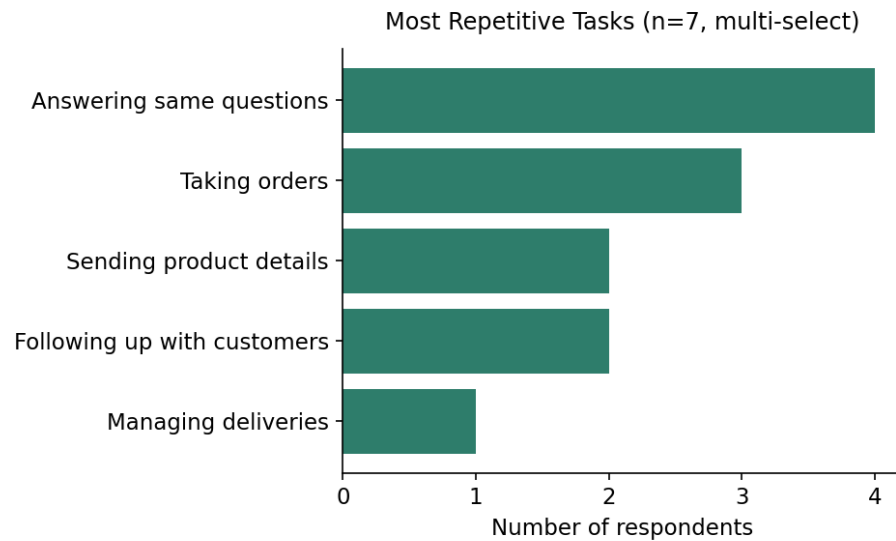
What customers ask about most

- Product price (4)
- Location (3)
- Delivery time (2)
- Product availability, delivery charges, payment methods, product recommendations (1 each)

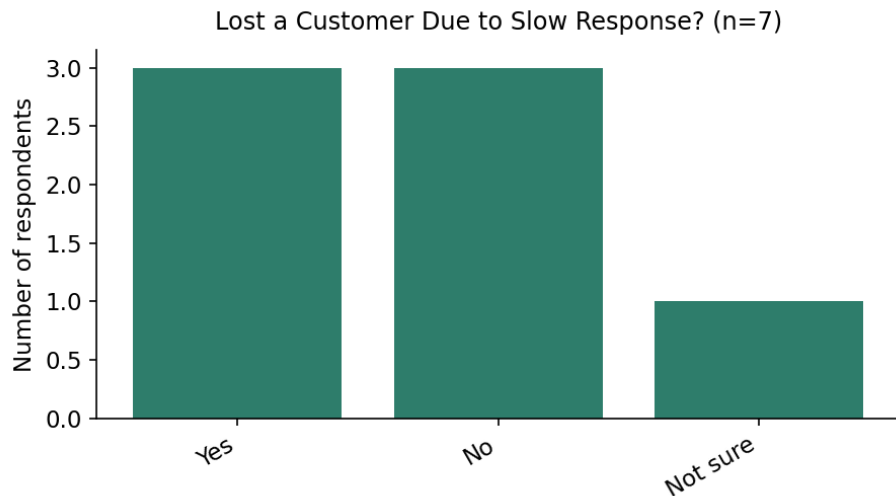


Pain points

- Most repetitive tasks: answering the same questions repeatedly (4), taking orders (3), sending product details (2), following up with customers (2)



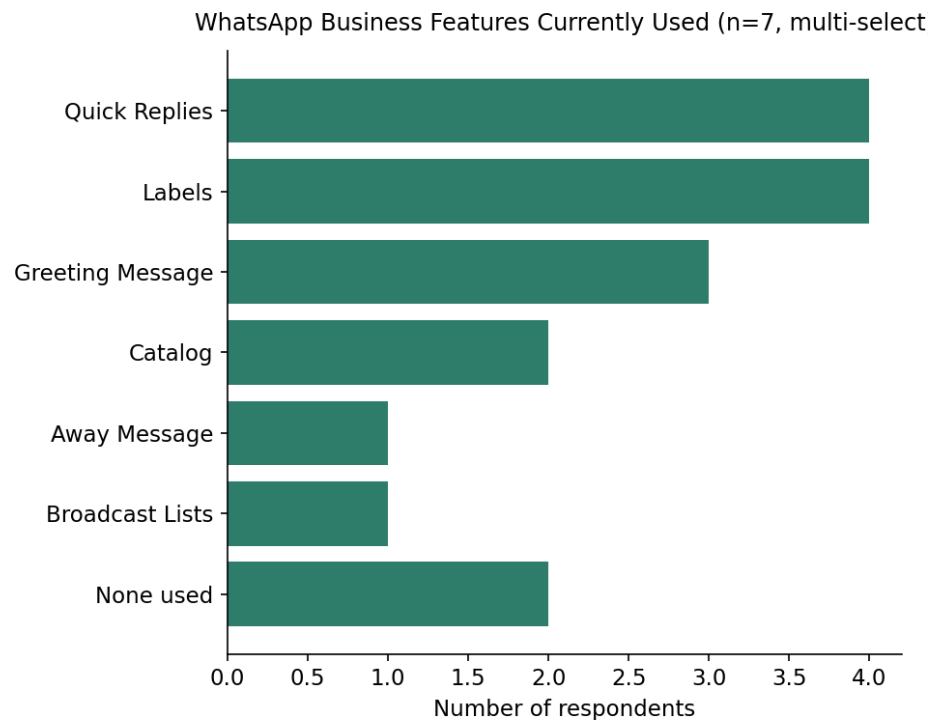
- 3 of 7 respondents have lost a customer due to slow response time, 3 said no, 1 was unsure



- Biggest cited challenges: pricing confusion (especially for customized products), lack of timely response, and handling multiple customers at once when most incoming questions are repeats of each other
- When asked what single task they would automate: answering repetitive questions and automating price/product detail responses came up most often

Existing tool usage

- WhatsApp Business features currently in use: Quick Replies (4), Labels (4), Catalog (2), Greeting Message (3), Away Message (1), Broadcast Lists (1)
- 2 of 7 respondents use no special features at all despite having WhatsApp Business



- Desired but missing features: automated replies, and a way to link an external system directly into WhatsApp
- 5 of 7 respondents agreed to a follow-up interview, indicating strong willingness to engage further

Part 2: User Interview Summary

Interviewee runs a home-based food business, primarily selling homemade meals to people who cannot cook for themselves, mainly hostel students from a nearby university. She also sells frozen food items during Ramadan and for parties and family gatherings (dawats).

Business background

- Running the business for 1.5 years, sourced almost entirely through WhatsApp with no separate social media presence
- Client acquisition was easy early on due to personal networks (was an HRM student at the time), so growth relied on word of mouth rather than paid or organic marketing
- Currently considering winding the business down, which surfaced naturally while discussing workload rather than being stated as a direct reason

Daily workflow

- Receives 25-30 messages per day, almost every day
- Menu is decided in advance on a weekly basis and posted daily to her WhatsApp status
- Orders are only accepted before 10am each day
- She caps orders based on how much she can realistically prepare (for example, capping biryani orders at 15 servings) and does not accept beyond that limit
- Once an item's order cap is reached, she posts an update to her status marking it as closed

Core pain point

The status update workaround does not fully solve the repetition problem, because not everyone views her WhatsApp status. Customers who miss the status still message her individually to ask whether today's menu item

is available, whether it is sold out, or when it will be ready, even after she has already communicated that information elsewhere.

Most repeated customer questions

- What is today's menu
- What is the half-serving price and portion size
- What time will the food be ready
- Can I place a customized order (only accepted 3 days in advance)
- Can I order frozen items for a dawlat (only accepted 3 days in advance)
- Is this item still available / has it sold out

What she wants automated

When asked directly what she would want WhatsApp (or an assistant acting on her behalf) to handle while she is away, she named two things specifically:

- Confirming the daily menu and order details to customers automatically
- Automatically notifying customers when an item's maximum order count is reached, so they find out it's sold out without needing to ask her directly

Key Insights for Small-Business Brain

- Repetitive question-answering is the single most consistent pain point across both the survey and the interview. This shows up as answering the same questions repeatedly in the survey (the top-cited repetitive task) and as the entire structure of the interviewee's daily WhatsApp load.
- Status updates are an underused workaround with a real gap. The interviewee already built her own manual system (weekly menu, status posts, order caps) to reduce repetition, but it fails because status visibility is inconsistent. This points to a concrete, narrow feature opportunity: an agent that proactively pushes availability and sold-out updates directly into chat rather than relying on a passive broadcast.
- Order-cap enforcement is a real, recurring workflow, not a hypothetical one. The interviewee already thinks in terms of hard caps per item per day. An agent that can track a running order count against a preset cap and auto-respond once it's hit would directly replace a manual step she performs every day.
- Willingness to delegate is high but scoped. She specifically wants automation for menu confirmation and availability updates, not full order-taking or payment handling. This suggests early product scope should prioritize information relay over end-to-end transaction handling.
- Time lost to repetition is likely undercounted in the survey. Most survey respondents reported spending well under an hour a day replying to messages, which understates the cognitive and time cost seen in the interview (25-30 messages daily, many repeats). This is worth probing further in additional interviews.
- Customized and advance orders need separate handling. Both the survey and interview surfaced a distinction between standard/repetitive inquiries and one-off customized requests (which need human judgment on pricing and feasibility). Any automation should clearly separate what it can resolve on its own from what it should escalate to the business owner.